

April 1, 1995

██████████, M.D.  
██████████  
██████████

Dear Dr. S██████████,

Steven asked me to thank you very much for the article you sent. He read it eagerly. If you have any other good controlled studies on the mind-matter connection he wanted me to ask if you would please forward them to him or send him the references. He thanks you tremendously for your support.

We all enjoyed meeting you in Florida and hope we will have the opportunity again.

Most sincerely,

██████████

# PEOPLE

THE SPACE COAST'S NEWSPAPER

FRIDAY, January 27, 1995

## The odd world of

The bookshelves are lined with display cases featuring the bizarre artistry of a 36-year-old man whom Billy Cox calls "a regular Mozart." There are quarters folded like tacos, spoons fused cleanly together so that the scoopers are at opposing ends, charred dollar bills, a penny heated into a smooth featureless disc, a quarter deplated of all silver.



**BILLY  
COX**  
PEOPLE

There are hours of videotape, too. A Coke can slides and waddles across a wooden table, a paperclip hovers above a flat surface, a lead pencil that should've dropped to the ground instead spins like an airplane propeller on the rim of a

quarter, sideways. On and on it goes.

The ringmaster is a dyslexic, grade-school dropout from Washington, Pa., named [REDACTED] a Vero Beach psychiatrist, has studied Nuzum for years. After producing some 1,900 pages of experiment transcripts, Schwarz is convinced his client is neither a magician nor an illusionist.

"Joey is one of those individuals who has been physiologically compensated for a lack of cognitive ability," Schwarz says. "Joey is in a trance state maybe 90 percent of the time. It's harmless dissociation, the way most of us doodle or daydream. He's in his own world. He makes reality conform to his own standards of vivid fantasy.

"I have tried," [REDACTED] continues heavily, "writing my beloved Dartmouth Medical School to get them to study Joey in a clinical setting. My ultimate goal would be the Mayo Clinic. He should be going around the country, to colleges, to schools, showing the world what one person is capable of doing. But I'm a total, miserable, 100 percent failure. Nobody's interested."

Nuzum, who teaches martial arts, relaxes in a rear room. He wears ninja black, as does his wife, Sandy. His greeting is cordial and restrained. He manages a distracted smile.

He says he had a stuttering problem as a child. When he was younger, inanimate objects had a tendency to move by themselves or break when he entered a room. "People didn't want to be around me, like I was a jinx." Kids picked on him; he learned to defend himself. He cured his fear of heights by jumping out of trees. "I have adventures in astral projection," he replies, when asked what he does for fun. "I share dreams with other people."

A slender metal spindle points up from its foundation in a melted candle stub. Nuzum asks for a dollar bill, which you balance on the spindle. You place an empty glass aquarium, open end down, over the candle, which rests on a small table. You seal the contact edges with masking tape. You wave your arms wildly near the aquarium, but the nothing moves.

Standing, Nuzum clenches his fists next to the glass. Minutes pass. The bill flinches suddenly. Nuzum glides his hand around the edges; the bill follows like a compass tracking magnetic north. This way, then that way. Then it's your turn. You move your free hand when he squeezes it. The bill swivels.

He balances an ink pen on the ledge of an acrylic bookend beneath the aquarium. In less than 30 seconds, the pen wobbles and flips down. "That was quick!" He removes a new, 15-watt fluorescent lightbulb from its cardboard packaging. The two of you balance the thing horizontally, against your palms. He clenches his free hand. The bulb flickers to life, into a dull ionized glow, once, twice.

"It's kind of embarrassing," he apologizes. "Normally I can get it a lot brighter."

The session is brief, a perfunctory 25 minutes. He saves his best for crowds. It can clobber him. Sometimes, he sleeps for two to three days afterwards.

Nuzum's advice to people who want to learn more about their own hidden powers is evasive. Or maybe not: "Do something nice for somebody, and don't tell them about it. See what happens.

"The rewards will be what you need." He weighs his words, lets them settle. "But different, perhaps, than what you gave."

*Billy Cox's column runs every Friday. He can be reached at 242-3774, or Florida Today, P.O. Box 419000, Melbourne, FL 32941-9000.*